From Covenant to Bloodline: Ezra-Nehemiah and the Idea of Inherited Holiness

by David D. Brosnahan

The Question

No one disputes that the covenant people were meant to marry within the covenant. The question is what "the covenant" meant. This essay argues that in the time of Ezra and Nehemiah a religious boundary was redefined as a genealogical one, that this shift was not necessary, and that the idea of inherited holiness it helped normalize resurfaced later in damaging forms.

Background: Babylon, Persia, and the Return

Babylon's policy toward conquered peoples was to deport leaders and destroy temples and cultural institutions. Persia took a different approach, allowing subject peoples to keep their temples and customs while remaining politically loyal. Under Persian rule the Jews were permitted to return to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple. According to Ezra 6, the work was completed under Zerubbabel, of David's line, and Joshua (Yeshua) son of Jehozadak, the high priest, with Haggai and Zechariah urging them on (see Zechariah 4:9).

Latter-day Saints add a perspective of their own. The Book of Mormon places Lehi and Jeremiah in a Jerusalem already drifting from the covenant in the days of Josiah's reforms, and some scholars also see those reforms as a period of heavy editing of Israel's scriptures. That reading is a matter of faith and contested scholarship, and this essay does not depend on it.

Ezra and Nehemiah: A Religious Boundary Becomes a Genealogical One

Ezra and Nehemiah arrive decades after the temple was finished, and they confront the problem of marriage to people of the surrounding lands. Two rationales appear side by side in the text.

The older rationale is religious. Deuteronomy 7:3-4 forbids intermarriage because foreign spouses would turn the children away from the Lord. That concern is answered by conversion, and the canon shows conversion was possible. Rahab joined Israel. Ruth the Moabite, a woman from a nation Deuteronomy 23:3 excludes, became the great-grandmother of David. Isaiah 56:3-7 promises the foreigner who joins himself to the Lord a place in the house of prayer for all peoples. Ezra 6:21 itself admits those who separated themselves from the practices of the nations and joined the community.

The newer rationale is genealogical. Ezra 9:2 describes the "holy seed" mixing with the peoples of the lands, which is language of descent. In Ezra 10, wives and their children are sent away, and the text never asks whether the women had joined the covenant. Scholars such as Christine Hayes read this as a shift toward descent as the basis of holiness. Defenders of Ezra note that Ezra 9:1 also cites the "abominations" of the surrounding peoples, so the concern was not purely ethnic. That is fair, but it makes the silence about conversion in Ezra 10 more striking, not less.

The word "racism" is anachronistic for the fifth century BCE, so I will speak of ethnic descent and genealogical holiness. The point stands: a boundary that could have been defined by faithfulness was defined by blood. The Book of Ruth, and perhaps Jonah, are often read as a counter-voice within the canon.

Malachi 2: One Possible Reading

Malachi 2 speaks of faithlessness to the wife of one's youth and of the Lord's hatred of putting away. I find it suggestive that this passage may address men who dismissed their wives, and it is possible it reflects the same period as Ezra's reforms. But the case is a hypothesis, not a demonstration. Malachi never names Ezra, and its dating is uncertain. Malachi 2:11 condemns marrying "the daughter of a foreign god," which most scholars read as cultic language supporting a religious concern about the marriages. Verse 16 is textually uncertain, with translations differing on whether it says the Lord hates divorce or says the man who hates his wife should divorce her. Many scholars read the chapter as condemning men who married foreign women and divorced Israelite wives, which would make it closer to Ezra's own concern than to a rebuke of it. The most responsible use of Malachi 2 is to present it as one reading that fits the argument, alongside the counter-reading.

The Wider Witness: All Are Alike unto God

Scripture repeatedly says God is no respecter of persons and that the covenant would reach the Gentiles. Abraham's household brought souls into the covenant in Haran. The genealogy of Jesus includes Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, and Bathsheba, women from diverse origins. In the Book of Mormon, 2 Nephi 26:33 says that all are alike unto God, black and white, bond and free, male and female, Jew and Gentile. A covenant defined by faith and obedience fits this witness much better than one defined by descent.

What Followed, and What We Can Claim

It is tempting to read everything afterward as the result of Ezra's reforms: the end of prophecy, the rabbinic system, the rejection of the Messiah, and the later scatterings. That chain is too long to prove. Rabbinic Judaism emerged after 70 CE, roughly five centuries later, and in between came the Hellenistic crisis, the Maccabees, and the rise of Pharisees, Sadducees, and Essenes. Jesus, his apostles, and the earliest church were Jews, and his rebukes of scribes and Pharisees were an internal critique, not a verdict on a whole people. Babylon destroyed Jerusalem before Ezra was born, so apostasy and judgment were already a pattern. Many historians also argue that Ezra and Nehemiah's firm boundaries helped Judaism survive exile and Hellenization.

A defensible claim is narrower. When holiness is tied to descent, it becomes a category that can be reused. Tension over who counted as authentic Israel is visible in later Jewish-Samaritan hostility, and in texts such as Jubilees that harden endogamy along lines of descent. Ezra-Nehemiah is an early and influential example, not the sole source.

The Latter-day Saint Mirror

Later ideas that skin color marked a curse, whether from Cain or from the pre-mortal life, drew mainly on readings of Genesis 4 and 9 that developed across Jewish, Christian, and Islamic interpretation and became bound up with the Atlantic slave trade. Brigham Young and Bruce R. McConkie were drawing on the nineteenth-century American Protestant world around them. Those ideas supported the priesthood and temple restriction, which President Spencer W. Kimball and the First Presidency ended by revelation in 1978, opening the priesthood to all worthy males and the temple to all worthy members. In the Church's 2013 Gospel Topics essay "Race and the Priesthood," the older explanations are disavowed outright.

In the aftermath of 1978, Elder McConkie urged members to forget what he, Brigham Young, or anyone else had said that was contrary to the light now received. His point is a fitting summary. Sacred communities can carry inherited ideas for generations and still be corrected by further light.

Conclusion

The argument is not against marrying in the covenant. It is that covenant membership was always meant to be defined by faith and faithfulness, as Ruth, Rahab, and Isaiah 56 show, and that treating it as a matter of blood was a choice, not a necessity. Seeing holiness as inherited gave later generations a template that could be misused. The restored gospel's answer is the one already in 2 Nephi 26:33: all are alike unto God.

Latter-day Saints also believe the Lord's house will draw people of every nation. The Salt Lake Temple is being renovated, with a public open house expected when it reopens, and the invitation is a fitting picture of a covenant open to all.